



U.S. strikes deal with S. Korea on tariffs

Agreement with India remains elusive ahead of Trump’s Friday deadline

BY JACOB BOGAGE, KARISHMA MEHROTRA AND MICHELLE YE HEE LEE

President Donald Trump said Wednesday he had reached a trade deal with South Korea ahead of a self-imposed Aug. 1 deadline before broad new taxes on imports kick in, though he also cast doubt on striking a deal with India, another of the United States’ largest trading partners.

South Korea was set to face a 25 percent tariff beginning Friday, when rates are set to go up on dozens of countries. Trump earlier Wednesday posted on Truth Social, his social media platform, that the Friday deadline “STANDS STRONG, AND WILL NOT BE EXTENDED.”

In the early evening, Trump wrote that South Korean imports will face a 15 percent tariff rate instead and that the country will invest \$350 billion in the U.S., directed by the White House, plus purchase \$100 billion in American energy.

South Korea is the country’s ninth-largest trading partner, according to federal data. India is the 12th largest. The U.S. and South Korea have an existing trade agreement that Trump negotiated during his first term.

South Korean President Lee Jae Myung welcomed the deal, which landed after negotiations started only last month when Lee

SEE TARIFFS ON A16

Argentina: Trump rewards Milei by skirting rules on visa waivers. **A11**

Surprising find 30,000 feet deep: Thriving life

BY DINO GRANDONI

When her three-person submarine descended more than 30,000 feet into one of the Pacific Ocean’s deepest trenches, Mengran Du wasn’t sure what they would find.

What she saw, she recalled, was “unbelievable”: Dense clusters of tubeworms with tentacles tinged blood-red, jutting up like skyscrapers. Iridescent snails scaling the worms like window washers. Bristle-covered creatures wriggling between them like rush-hour commuters trying to get home for dinner.

An international team of researchers has discovered the world’s deepest known ecosystems sustained by chemicals seeping from the sea floor. Submerged in water and darkness, the discovery expands the limits of where we know life can live on Earth, and even suggests ways in which extraterrestrial organisms may have evolved in oceans on other worlds.

“It’s a unique ecosystem,” said Dominic Papineau, an exobiologist who co-wrote the study on the deep-sea discovery published Wednesday in the journal Nature. “It’s a totally new thing that has not been seen before.”

The bottom dwellers, found in the Kuril-Kamchatka and Aleutian trenches between Alaska

SEE DEEP SEA ON A8

Russia’s unrelenting attacks leave destruction in Ukraine



SERGEY KOZLOV/EPA/SHUTTERSTOCK

A Ukrainian first responder works at the site of a strike in Kharkiv’s outskirts Wednesday. Ukraine’s air force said Russia launched 78 drone attacks overnight, as Moscow continued its intensified aerial campaign against cities. The Kharkiv region’s governor said Wednesday that Russian attacks had killed six there in the past day.

An AI future powered by geriatric nuclear plants

BY EVAN HALPER AND CAROLINE O’DONOVAN

MIDDLETOWN, PA. — The control room at Three Mile Island doesn’t call to mind modern-day Silicon Valley.

The nuclear plant’s gadgetry has plastic levers and colored buttons chunky enough for a toddler’s play set; push-button landline phones; and monochrome monitors. But vintage facilities like these are now coveted by tech companies that need immense amounts of power today to propel their dreams for tomorrow.

The nation’s dwindling fleet of nuclear plants is being seized upon by tech firms such as Microsoft and Amazon as a foundation for their plans for an artificial intelligence-infused future. The aged but reliable survivors have emerged as one of the most viable ways to quickly feed tech firms’ growing thirst for electricity to power the giant data centers needed for AI projects.

As tech firms race for reactor output, regular consumers may lose out

Meta signed a 20-year agreement for the power flowing from a large legacy reactor in Illinois; Microsoft struck a deal to restart a reactor next to the one at

Pennsylvania’s Three Mile Island that was shuttered in 1979 by a partial meltdown; and Amazon last month in the same state locked up power from a 42-year-old nuclear plant down the Susquehanna River.

Tech companies are scouring the nation for other geriatric nuclear plants to power their AI dreams, according to interviews with nuclear industry officials and company earnings calls. Their interest is focused on the roughly two dozen operating plants in unregulated markets, which are in many cases free to sell power to the highest bidder. They make up about half of the 54 plants still operating in the United States.

The tech firms say the deals

give new life to plants that are at risk of going offline or have already been shut down. Contracts that lock in rates for decades are attractive to plant operators, and the electricity flows without directly generating new carbon emissions.

But critics say Silicon Valley’s nuclear spree makes it more likely that consumers will face electricity rate hikes or shortages in coming years as the nation faces soaring demand for power — driven in part by new data centers.

By locking up aging nuclear plants instead of building new power generation, tech firms could leave communities to fall back on fossil fuels, extending

SEE POWER ON A9

After massive quake, a relatively tame tsunami

8.8-magnitude temblor off Russia has so far created smaller waves than past strong quakes

BY KASHA PATEL AND SCOTT DANCE

An 8.8-magnitude earthquake — one of the most powerful ever recorded — struck off the coast of eastern Russia late Tuesday, causing intense shaking for minutes, rattling windows and damaging infrastructure nearby. In the following hours, people in Japan, Hawaii and along the U.S. West Coast braced for an often deadly effect of coastal earthquakes: a tsunami.

Past strong earthquakes have caused massive and damaging waves far away, but scientists say these tsunami waves were tame by comparison across the Pacific basin, at least so far. Wednesday evening, some areas of South America were still preparing for an incoming tsunami.

Researchers and response teams are still uncovering specific details about the event, but better warning systems and the other properties of the quake beyond its strength may have mitigated the effects so far.

“It definitely created a Pacific-

SEE TSUNAMI ON A12



NICHOLA GROOM/REUTERS

People at a resort in Honolulu on Tuesday look toward Waikiki Beach after authorities warned of the possibility of tsunami waves following an 8.8-magnitude earthquake off the coast of eastern Russia.

Revisiting the record: How does the earthquake compare to disasters that hit Chile, Japan and more? **A12**

A host of failures outlined in crash

LAPSES BY FAA AND MILITARY, NTSB SAYS

Officials questioned over disaster above Potomac

This article is by Ian Duncan, Tara Copp, Lori Aratani, Alex Horton and Rachel Weiner

Investigators painted a devastating picture Wednesday of numerous mistakes and government failures that converged at a tragic point 278 feet above the Potomac River on Jan. 29, in the fullest public airing of factors in the collision of a regional passenger jet and an Army Black Hawk helicopter that cost 67 lives.

National Transportation Safety Board investigators grilled Federal Aviation Administration and Army officials for not taking action after years of warnings from air traffic controllers and others about dangers in the busy airspace around Reagan National Airport, which is crowded with military and civilian aircraft.

They released thousands of pages of documents about equipment faults aboard Army helicopters, confusion and limited visibility for the helicopter crew on the night of the crash, control tower staffing, and missed opportunities to reduce clear risks.

The documents — released at the start of three days of public hearings on the crash — include the first account from the

SEE CRASH ON A6

Helicopter fleet: Army expands use of navigation devices. **A6**

DOJ: Epstein grand jury files have just 2 witnesses

BY JEREMY ROEBUCK

The grand jury transcripts the Justice Department is seeking to make public from its investigation of disgraced financier and sex offender Jeffrey Epstein and his associate Ghislaine Maxwell include testimony from only two witnesses, both of them law enforcement officers, government lawyers said.

That disclosure, made in a court filing late Tuesday, raises questions over whether the department’s push to unseal those transcripts will satisfy the clamoring of President Donald Trump’s base for greater transparency surrounding the Epstein investigation.

While it is not unusual for grand juries to hear from only law enforcement witnesses as they weigh whether to indict a defendant, such testimony is offered to provide a summary of the broader evidence investigators have gathered and does not often provide the type of detailed accounting that typically emerges at trials.

Still, earlier this month the Justice Department, acting on orders from Trump, asked federal judges in Manhattan and Florida to unseal those grand jury transcripts amid unrelenting pressure from some of the president’s allies, who

SEE EPSTEIN ON A4

White House: Advisers say storm within Trump’s base has calmed. **A5**

IN THE NEWS

Economy shows strength The Commerce Department reported growth at an annual clip of 3 percent in the second quarter, boosted by an imports slowdown amid trade turmoil. **A14**

Immigration checks Interim U.S. attorney for D.C. Jeanine Pirro intensified her cooperation with ICE amid deportation crackdowns. **B13**

THE NATION **New York’s** mass killing will lead many corporations to fortify their offices, experts said. **A3** **Kamala Harris** said she won’t run for California governor, leaving a door open for 2028. **A7**

THE WORLD **Thousands** in Birmingham, England, gathered for Ozzy Osbourne’s funeral procession. **A10** **Canada** became the latest country to say it is prepared to recognize a Palestinian state. **A11**

THE ECONOMY **NASA workforce cuts** and impermanent leadership stoked fears about the safety of future space missions. **A13** **Some household** staples will soon get costlier, as Procter & Gamble said it would raise prices for about a quarter of its products. **A14**

STYLE **Fan fiction writers** used to be relegated to the internet. Now they’re shaking up traditional publishing. **B1**

SPORTS **For one lawyer**, the fight for college athlete employment has become his life’s work. And he won’t let it go. **B7**

THE REGION **A former Prince** George’s council member became chief of staff for another after serving time for theft of campaign funds. **B13**

LOCAL LIVING **For online shoppers**, the internet is a sprawling mall — and we are all trapped inside.

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